

ISO 14001:2015 to ISO 14001:2026 Transition Cheat Sheet

Auditor-focused quick reference for clause-wise changes, screenshot selection and audit evidence

Purpose: Compare ISO 14001:2015 with ISO 14001:2026 clause by clause.

Clause	What changed in 2026	Type/location	Screenshot snippets to take	Auditor focus / evidence
4 Context	Environmental conditions are now named more explicitly: pollution levels, natural resource availability, climate change, biodiversity and ecosystem health. Interested party expectations may also relate to these environmental conditions. EMS scope now links control/influence to life cycle of activities, products and services.	Requirement text + Note + scope wording	2015: 4.1 line on environmental conditions. 2026: 4.1 line naming pollution/natural resources/climate/biodiversity/ecosystem health. 2026: 4.2 NOTE 1 on interested party expectations related to environmental conditions. 2026: 4.3 line on control/influence over life cycle.	Updated context analysis, stakeholder register, EMS scope, lifecycle influence, linkage to risks/opportunities and planning.
5 Leadership	Terminology changes to “meet compliance obligations”. Policy note gives clearer examples: preservation/conservation of natural resources, sustainable resource use, climate change mitigation/adaptation, biodiversity and ecosystems. Leadership support for relevant roles remains important.	Terminology + Note + policy commitment	2015: 5.2 commitment to fulfil compliance obligations. 2026: 5.2 commitment to meet compliance obligations. 2026: 5.2 NOTE on natural resources, climate change mitigation/adaptation, biodiversity and ecosystems.	Updated policy, leadership resource decisions, communication records, role support, management review outputs.
6 Planning	Planning is restructured: risks/opportunities separated into 6.1.4 and planning action into 6.1.5. New 6.3 Planning of changes added. Aspect evaluation now separates normal, abnormal and emergency situations more clearly and links changes to 6.3.	Structure + new clause + requirement text + Note	2015: contents showing 6.1.4 Planning action. 2026: contents showing 6.1.4 Risks and opportunities, 6.1.5 Planning action and 6.3 Planning of changes. 2015: 6.1.2 abnormal conditions and emergency situations together. 2026: 6.1.2 normal/abnormal/change/potential emergency situations separately. 2026: 6.1.2 NOTE 1 on life cycle stages.	Risk register, action plans, aspect-impact register, emergency scenario records, EMS change review records, objectives/KPIs, effectiveness evaluation.
7 Support	Terminology around documented information is clarified: information should be available, suitable for use where and when needed. Internal communication should enable people to contribute to continual improvement. Competence remains linked to environmental performance and compliance obligations.	Terminology + requirement text	2015: 7.5 documented information maintained/retained wording. 2026: A.3 terminology note explaining “available as documented information” and “available as evidence”. 2026: 7.4.2(b) communication enables contribution to continual improvement. 2026: 7.5.3 available and suitable where/when needed.	Role-based competence, awareness interviews, communication records, point-of-use procedures, document access/revision control.

Clause Comparison Continued

Clause	What changed in 2026	Type/location	Screenshot snippets to take	Auditor focus / evidence
8 Operation	“Outsource/outsources processes” terminology is replaced with “externally provided processes, products or services”. Lifecycle operational control is strengthened across design, procurement, external provider communication and disposal/end-of-life information. Emergency preparedness remains linked to potential emergencies from 6.1.2.	Terminology + requirement text	2015: definition 3.3.4 outsource OR 8.1 outsourced processes. 2026: A.3 note saying outsource deleted/replaced by externally provided processes, products or services. 2026: 8.1 external providers and life cycle bullets. 2026: 8.2 emergency preparedness linked to 6.1.2.	Supplier/contractor controls, procurement criteria, externally provided process controls, lifecycle controls, emergency drill/test/review records.
9 Performance evaluation	More explicit requirement to evaluate environmental performance and EMS effectiveness. Internal audits must define audit objectives, criteria and scope. Management review is restructured into 9.3.1 General, 9.3.2 Inputs and 9.3.3 Results.	Requirement text + structure	2015: 9.2.2 define audit criteria and scope. 2026: 9.2.2 define audit objective(s), audit criteria and scope. 2015: 9.3 Management review single section. 2026: contents showing 9.3.1/9.3.2/9.3.3. 2026: 9.1.1 evaluate environmental performance and EMS effectiveness.	KPI trend analysis, monitoring/measurement results, audit objectives, audit follow-up, management review decisions/actions/resources.
10 Improvement	Separate 10.3 Continual improvement removed. Continual improvement is now 10.1 and linked with Clause 9 and 10.2. Corrective action wording includes cause(s), similar nonconformities, recurrence prevention and effectiveness review.	Structure + requirement text	2015: contents showing 10.1 General, 10.2 Nonconformity and corrective action, 10.3 Continual improvement. 2026: contents showing 10.1 Continual improvement and 10.2 Nonconformity and corrective action. 2026: 10.2 wording on cause(s), similar nonconformities and effectiveness review.	Root cause analysis, similar issue review, corrective action effectiveness, recurrence prevention, improvement KPIs/performance evidence.

Auditor Quick Checklist

Clause 4: ☐ context includes climate/pollution/biodiversity/ecosystem/natural resources ☐ interested party environmental expectations reviewed ☐ scope reflects lifecycle control/influence

Clause 5: ☐ policy uses meet compliance obligations ☐ policy commitments align with context ☐ leadership support evidenced

Clause 6: ☐ risk identification separate from action planning ☐ normal/abnormal/emergency evaluated distinctly ☐ change management under 6.3 documented

Clause 7: ☐ competence is role-based ☐ communication supports continual improvement ☐ documents available at point of use

Clause 8: ☐ external providers controlled/influenced ☐ lifecycle controls applied ☐ emergency response tested and reviewed

Clause 9: ☐ performance and EMS effectiveness analyzed ☐ audit objectives defined ☐ management review gives decisions/actions/resources

Clause 10: ☐ root causes identified ☐ similar issues checked ☐ effectiveness verified and performance improved

Big Transition Themes

Environmental conditions | Leadership accountability | Structured planning | EMS change management | Lifecycle thinking | External provider control | Audit objectives | EMS effectiveness | Evidence-based improvement

Source note: Prepared from user-provided ISO 14001:2015 and BS EN ISO 14001:2026 documents. This cheat sheet is a training aid and does not replace the official standards.